How to Use It: Space, Timing, Families

The part of companion planting that works every time, in every garden

RULE 1 — THE 3-YEAR FAMILY RULE

Pests and diseases stick to one plant family. Do not grow a family in the same spot more often than once every 3 years. This is the strongest bad-neighbor rule there is, and it is about time, not distance.

Know the families — these move together

Nightshade	Tomato, potato, pepper, eggplant, tomatillo
Cabbage / mustard	Broccoli, cabbage, kale, cauliflower, radish, turnip, arugula, mustard
Squash & melon	Squash, zucchini, pumpkin, cucumber, melon, watermelon
Bean & pea	Beans, peas, cowpeas, edamame, clover, vetch, peanut
Onion	Onion, garlic, leek, shallot, chives, asparagus
Carrot	Carrot, celery, parsnip, parsley, dill, fennel, cilantro
Beet	Beet, spinach, Swiss chard
Grass	Sweet corn, oats, rye, wheat, barley, sorghum
Sunflower	Lettuce, sunflower, artichoke, endive, chicory, tarragon

Rule 2 — tall on the north edge

Anything tall or trellised throws a shadow. Put it on the north side of the bed so it does not shade the short crops.
The one time you want that shade: lettuce and spinach in high summer.

Rule 3 — trap crops go outside

A trap crop pulls pests toward it. Planted inside the patch it brings them in.
Ring the outside of the bed, on the side the bugs come from. A mix of 3 or more trap plants beats one.

Rule 4 — give them the room on the label

Crowded plants sit in still, damp air, and that is how leaf disease starts.
Thin seedlings even when it feels harsh. Fewer, bigger plants beat a crowded row.

Rule 5 — use time as well as space

Plant lettuce, spinach or basil early, then set tomatoes or peppers into the same bed.
Slip radishes between slow plants. They are pulled before the big crop needs the room.

The 10-second check before you pair any two plants

- ☐ Same family? Then they share pests — and they cannot follow each other for 3 years.
- ☐ Which one is taller? Tall goes north, short goes south.
- ☐ Do they both want the same light and water? Mismatched needs, unhappy plants.
- ☐ Is a black walnut within 50 to 80 feet? Then no tomatoes, potatoes, peppers or eggplants here - there is no cure.

Where this page comes from

NC State Extension: families, the 3-year rule, shade, crowding, timing. Univ. of Minnesota Ext. and UConn IPM: trap crops, early crops. Univ. of Wisconsin Ext. and Penn State Ext.: black walnut.
Free sample: page 4 of 5 in the Companion Planting Chart (Etsy: ForrestFinds5433). Made with the help of AI tools.